The Traditional Naming System of the Mising People

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Abstract

This study explores the possibility of a traditional syllable-based naming system among the Mising people, an indigenous community belonging to the wider Tani ethnolinguistic group of Northeast India. It investigates the hypothesis that traditional personal names commonly consisted of two syllables, with the final syllable of a father's name becoming the initial syllable of his child's name. Using a qualitative, exploratory, and comparative approach, the study examines selected genealogical traditions associated with the Kepang and Longging clans, alongside linguistic observations, oral traditions, and comparative evidence from other Tani communities. It also considers the tradition of Pédong Na:né to explore questions of ancestry, kinship, and possible exceptions to the proposed pattern. The findings reveal several apparent syllabic correspondences between successive names, although other transitions require further linguistic examination. The study also discusses how social change, cultural contact, and religious influences may have affected naming practices over time. However, the available evidence is insufficient to establish the proposed pattern as a widespread or historically confirmed Mising naming rule. By documenting these observations and identifying areas requiring further investigation, this study contributes to the discussion of Mising naming traditions and highlights the importance of oral histories, genealogical documentation, and linguistic research in understanding the community's cultural heritage.

Keywords: Anthroponymy, Mising traditional naming system, Onomastics, Intergenerational syllable transmission, Genealogical naming patterns, Oral traditions, Mising language, Changing naming practices

Introduction

The Mising, also historically referred to as the Miri, are an indigenous people of Northeast India who belong to the wider Tani ethnolinguistic group. Their principal population is found in the Indian states of Assam and Arunachal Pradesh, particularly in the Brahmaputra Valley and adjoining hill areas. The Mising language, *Mising Agom*, belongs to the Tani branch of the Sino-Tibetan (Tibeto-Burman) language family and is closely related to the languages of neighbouring Tani communities such as the Adi, Nyishi, Galo, and Apatani. Traditionally, Mising life has been closely connected to rivers, agriculture, fishing, weaving, and community-based social practices, which together shape a distinct cultural identity. Cultural knowledge, including beliefs, rituals, folk narratives, songs, genealogies, and customary practices, has largely been transmitted through oral traditions across generations. Within this broader cultural setting, personal names form an important part of Mising social and cultural life, reflecting the community's shared history, values, and relationship with the natural and social world.

Traditional Mising names are closely related to family, ancestry, and community identity. Mising society is divided into different clans, known as *Opín*, which are traditionally connected to common ancestors. Mising genealogical traditions identify Gu:mín as one of the early ancestors of the plains Misings, whose descendants are associated with different *Opín*. The names of many *Opín* are also represented by surnames used in Mising society today. However, Mising naming and family practices may have changed over time, and some accounts suggest that earlier Mising society had matrilineal elements. According to Padun (1970), until

the second half of the nineteenth century, Mising people did not commonly use clan names as surnames and instead identified themselves through their father's name. These traditions and historical accounts show that Mising names and surnames have changed over time and are closely connected with ancestry and social identity.

One possible pattern in traditional Mising naming practices concerns the structure of personal names and the relationship between a father and child. This study proposes that traditional Mising personal names may often have consisted of two syllables. It further examines the possibility that the final syllable of a father's name may have become the first syllable of his child's name. Such a pattern may be reflected in Mising oral traditions and genealogical accounts, where similar syllables appear across successive generations. However, these accounts alone cannot establish that the pattern was a fixed rule followed by all Mising people. Comparative evidence from other Tani communities, especially the Galo, describes a disyllabic naming system in which a child's initial syllable derives from the father's name, but this evidence cannot be treated as direct proof of a Mising system (Post, 2013). Therefore, this study will examine the proposed pattern through Mising oral traditions, genealogical information, and linguistic observations.

Although the Mising have a rich body of oral literature, the traditional personal naming system has not received detailed and sustained academic attention. Existing studies often discuss Mising folklore, clan organisation, language, and rituals, but they do not systematically examine how personal names were formed or whether syllables were transmitted between parents and children. This creates a research gap that this study seeks to address. Oral sources are especially important because much Mising cultural knowledge was historically transmitted through speech rather than writing. A:bang, more fully *Mibu A:bang*, is a traditional Mising oral form of sacred chant or priestly song performed by the *Mibu*, or priest. It preserves accounts of origins, ancestors, cosmology, and social order, and is therefore a valuable source for understanding community memory. However, A:bang should be treated as contextual oral evidence rather than as direct proof of a fixed naming rule. By combining A:bang and other oral accounts with genealogical information and linguistic observation, this study examines the possible relationship between parental and children's names and contributes to the documentation of Mising cultural heritage.

Literature Review

Research on the Mising people has generally concentrated on history, migration, social organization, religion, folklore, language, and ethnic identity rather than on personal naming systems. The Mising, formerly referred to in many external sources as "Miri," are generally located within the wider Tani ethnolinguistic grouping, alongside communities such as the Adi, Galo, Nyishi, Apatani, and Tagin. Their language belongs to the Tibeto-Burman branch of the Sino-Tibetan family, although the precise historical relationships among Tani languages remain a subject of linguistic research (Das & Doley, 2024; Sun, 1993). Oral traditions, linguistic similarities, and shared origin narratives provide evidence of historical connections, but they should not be treated as proof of a single, uniform Tani culture or naming system.

Ethnographic and historical studies describe Mising society as organized through patrilineal clans known as *Opín*. These clans are generally associated with descent from a common male ancestor and are linked to clan exogamy and wider community endogamy. A University of Hyderabad dissertation, for example, describes the *Opín* as patrilineal groups formed by the descendants of a common male ancestor and notes that clans may contain further subdivisions (Mishong,

2019, pp. 32–37). Other Mising studies similarly identify the clan as an important unit of social identity, marriage regulation, kinship, and ancestry. However, the number and classification of clans vary between sources. Some writers identify approximately fifty-one clans, whereas other community-based publications list more subdivisions. This variation suggests that clan classification is historically and regionally flexible rather than a completely standardized system.

Mising genealogical traditions are also connected with the figure of Gu:mín or Gumín and with broader Tani origin narratives involving Abotani. These accounts commonly represent Mising clans as related groups descended from an ancestral line. Such traditions are significant because they connect clan identity, ancestry, ritual relations, and restrictions on marriage. Nevertheless, the historical status of Gu:mín is difficult to establish through documentary evidence. The figure appears most securely within oral and cultural traditions rather than independently verifiable historical records. Genealogical knowledge has traditionally been transmitted through ritual specialists, family elders, clan narratives, and oral performances. Consequently, genealogies are valuable evidence of how Mising people understand ancestry, but they must be distinguished from genealogies reconstructed through written archival documentation.

A:bang is particularly important in this context. Available scholarship does not support reducing A:bang to ordinary "folk songs." It is more accurately described as a ritual or priestly verbal performance associated especially with the *Mibu*, the Mising ritual specialist. A:bang may include invocations, cosmological narratives, creation accounts, migration traditions, genealogical references, and ritual knowledge. Studies of Mising oral literature describe religious songs as A:bang and distinguish them from other forms such as love songs, lullabies, nursery rhymes, and lamentation songs (Kalita, 2020, pp. 500–502). The Assam Institute of Research for Tribals and Scheduled Castes also records that Mising folk literature preserves social values, migration memories, historical events, and cultural practices (Kuli, 1992). A:bang can therefore legitimately be used as evidence in research on naming, especially where it preserves sequences of ancestors or relationships between kin. However, it is mediated evidence: performances may vary between Mibu lineages, localities, and occasions, and mythic or ritual language cannot automatically be read as a literal historical record.

The claim attributed to Nahendra Padun that Mising people did not commonly use clan names as surnames until the second half of the nineteenth century requires careful treatment. The claim appears in later discussions of Mising identity and is cited to Padun's essay "Gotra Devota (Gumin)" in *Mising Sanskritir Alekhya* (Padun, 1970, p. 289). A later dissertation reports that Padun and Ganesh Pegu argued that earlier Mising individuals identified themselves through their father's name rather than through a clan name, and that "Miri" was used by many people as a surname or external identity marker (Doley, n.d., Chapter IV). However, the accessible evidence does not establish that Padun's original discussion was based on a systematic survey of historical records. Nor does it demonstrate that the practice was uniform throughout all Mising regions. The claim should therefore be cited as an interpretation or historical argument, not as a confirmed universal rule.

The available literature also does not provide strong, direct evidence that traditional Mising personal names generally consisted of two syllables or that the final syllable of a father's name was regularly transferred to the beginning of a child's name. Existing Mising grammars and language studies mainly discuss phonology, morphology, vocabulary, dialect variation, script development, and

language contact. They do not appear to document a systematic father-to-child syllable rule (Das & Doley, 2024). This is an important distinction: the absence of documentation does not disprove the proposed pattern, but it means that the pattern remains an open research question.

Comparative Tani evidence is relevant but limited. Research on the Galo community explicitly documents a generally disyllabic naming pattern in which the last syllable of the father's name may become the first syllable of the child's name. Doye calls the inherited element a "patri-syllable" and describes the second element as an individually selected syllable (Doye, 2020, pp. 105–107). The article also reports exceptions involving paternal uncles and, more recently, paternal aunts. Seminar commentary on Tani naming practices further contrasts Galo naming with Nyishi and Apatani systems and states that a similar last-syllable pattern among Adi and Nyishi communities may be limited to ritual or mythological contexts (Ete, 2021). These studies provide a useful comparative model, but they cannot prove that the same system existed among the Mising. Indeed, the variation within Galo itself demonstrates that naming practices may be contextual, regional, and historically changeable.

Historical change must also be considered. Mising interaction with Assamese society, the Ahom state, Vaishnavism, education, Christian missions, colonial administration, and modern state documentation affected language, religion, settlement, and public identity. Studies describe the expansion of Assamese language and Vaishnavite practices, including the importance of *Naamghar*, while Christian influence remained numerically smaller but historically visible (Doley, n.d., pp. 138–140; Pegu, 2013). Administrative categories, school records, electoral documents, and legal forms may also have encouraged the stabilization of inherited clan names as surnames. However, the literature does not yet provide a sufficiently detailed chronological study showing exactly when or why each Mising naming practice changed.

Overall, previous research establishes the importance of patrilineal clans, ancestry, oral tradition, A:bang, and historical interaction with Assamese society. It also provides a strong comparative precedent from Galo naming. Nevertheless, focused academic research on the structural relationship between Mising fathers' and children's personal names remains very limited. The proposed study therefore addresses a genuine, though not absolute, research gap. Its contribution will depend on comparing A:bang passages, oral genealogies, family histories, historical documents, and linguistic data while treating the two-syllable and father-to-child syllable patterns as hypotheses to be tested rather than as established Mising rules.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative, exploratory, and comparative approach to examine the traditional naming system of the Mising people. It is based on interactions with members of other Tani communities, comparative observations of naming practices, and the development of a hypothesis concerning traditional Mising personal names. The study explores the possibility that personal names commonly consisted of two syllables and that the final syllable of a father's name may have been used as the first syllable of his child's name. This proposed pattern is treated as a hypothesis rather than an established naming rule.

The primary basis of the study consists of information and observations obtained through interactions with people belonging to other Tani communities, particularly regarding their naming traditions and the relationships between names across generations. These interactions provide comparative perspectives that may help

identify similarities and differences between Tani naming practices. Available academic literature, linguistic studies, historical accounts, genealogical traditions, and published materials on Mising culture are also considered where relevant. The study distinguishes between information obtained through community interactions, observations made by the researcher, and claims documented in existing literature.

The analysis focuses on the structure of personal names, the occurrence of recurring syllables, and possible relationships between the names of parents and their children. These patterns are examined alongside variations and exceptions in the available information. Comparative evidence from communities such as the Galo, Adi, Nyishi, and Apatani is used to provide a broader Tani context. However, similarities observed in other communities are not considered sufficient evidence to establish that the same naming practice existed among the Mising.

The study also considers how historical and social changes, including interaction with Assamese society, religious influences, education, and administrative record-keeping, may have affected naming practices over time. Since the proposed explanation is partly based on the researcher's own observations and interpretation, the conclusions remain exploratory. The limited availability of direct historical evidence and the possibility of variation between communities are acknowledged. Further systematic interviews, genealogical research, and linguistic analysis would be required to evaluate the hypothesis more conclusively.

Findings and Analysis

This section examines the possibility of a traditional syllable-based naming pattern among the Mising people. Through comparative observations of naming practices among other Tani communities and an examination of Mising ancestral genealogies, this study explores whether a recurring relationship exists between the names of successive generations. The proposed pattern is analysed as a hypothesis, with particular attention to ancestral names and genealogical sequences that may provide clues to an earlier naming tradition.

The Proposed Syllable-Based Naming Pattern

This study proposes that a syllable-based naming pattern may have existed in the traditional naming system of the Mising people. The idea developed when the authors observed naming patterns among other Tani communities and began examining Mising ancestral genealogies for possible similarities. Although this pattern is not commonly observed in present-day Mising names, the genealogical accounts examined in this study suggest a possibility that it may have existed in an earlier period. This study therefore explores selected ancestral names to investigate whether a consistent relationship can be identified between the names of successive generations. However, this proposed pattern remains a hypothesis and requires further evidence before any definite conclusion can be drawn.

A syllable is a unit of pronunciation within a word or name. A name may contain one or more syllables, depending on how it is pronounced. In this study, the term “syllable-based naming pattern” refers to the proposed relationship between the syllables of names belonging to successive generations. Examining the pronunciation and structure of ancestral names may help determine whether such a pattern exists in the genealogical traditions of the Mising people.

The Proposed Rule and Its Examples

The proposed naming rule suggests that the final syllable of a father's name becomes the initial syllable of his child's name. According to this hypothesis, a syllable is carried forward from one generation to the next, creating a possible

connection between successive names in a genealogy. For example, in the sequence:

Do:ni → Nibo → Bomi

The final syllable of Do:ni, "ni," corresponds to the beginning of Nibo, while the final syllable of Nibo, "bo," corresponds to the beginning of Bomi. This study examines whether the same pattern can be identified in other ancestral names and genealogical accounts associated with the Mising people. At this stage, the sequence is treated as a possible pattern for investigation, rather than conclusive proof of a historical naming system.

To examine this hypothesis further, the study considers ancestral names found in the genealogical traditions of different Mising clans. These genealogies may help determine whether the proposed syllable pattern appears repeatedly across generations or only in selected names. The following analysis focuses on the genealogical accounts associated with the Kepang and Longgíng clans. As these accounts are based on traditional genealogical information, their details and the proposed pattern require further documentation and verification.

The Role of ":" and "ng" in the Naming Pattern

In Mising romanisation, the colon (:) placed after a vowel indicates vowel elongation and can distinguish words with different meanings. For example, *Dopid* refers to dropping food while eating, whereas *Do:pid* refers to drizzle or fine drops of rain. This distinction is important when examining traditional names because vowel length is not merely a writing variation. It can affect the meaning and interpretation of a word. Therefore, the colon must be preserved when recording and analysing ancestral names.

The use of the suffix *-ng*, representing the velar nasal sound /ŋ/, is another important feature of Mising linguistic structure. According to the observations presented in this study, its occurrence depends on the phonological environment and grammatical context. In certain forms, adding *-ng* is associated with a change in vowel length, as illustrated by *do:lu: ~ do* and *ílíng ~ ílí:*. Its use also varies according to whether a word is quoted, occurs at the end of a sentence, is spoken independently, or is followed by particular sounds. However, these patterns are not universal across all speakers and dialects. Some words retain long vowels without taking *-ng*, while certain dialects show different usage patterns.

These features are relevant to the proposed syllable-based naming hypothesis because the written form of a name must be interpreted according to Mising conventions rather than judged solely by its spelling. The analysis of ancestral names must therefore consider vowel length, the occurrence or absence of *-ng*, and dialectal variation before determining whether successive names follow the proposed pattern.

Examples of Vowel Length and "-ng" Usage

Form 1	Form 2	Feature
Dopid	Do:pid	Meaning changes
Do:lu:	Do:lung	Vowel length and -ng
Ílí:	ílíng	-ng variation
sibe:	sibeng	Dialectal change

Analysis of the Kepang Genealogy

According to the genealogical account examined in this study, the ancestry associated with the Kepang clan begins with Do:ni, identified in the tradition as Abotani. The sequence continues through Nibo, Bomi, Midong, Do:lo, Lonung, Nu:da, Dayi, Yike, Kepang, and Pa:pér. This sequence provides an opportunity to examine whether the proposed syllable-

based naming pattern can be observed across successive generations.

Do:ni → Nibo → Bomi → Midong → Do:lo → Lonung → Nu:da → Dayi → Yike → Kepang → Pa:pér

The first transition, Do:ni → Nibo, follows the proposed naming pattern because the final syllable of Do, "ni," corresponds to the initial syllable of Nibo. Similarly, the transition Nibo → Bomi follows the pattern because the final syllable of Nibo, "bo," corresponds to the initial syllable of Bomi. These examples provide an initial basis for examining whether the same relationship appears in the remaining names of the genealogy.

The next transition, Bomi → Midong, requires further examination to determine whether it follows the proposed naming pattern. Rather than judging the relationship solely by the written forms of the names, the analysis must consider their pronunciation and the naming conventions of the Mising language. This approach helps avoid drawing conclusions based only on apparent similarities or differences in spelling.

The subsequent transitions, Midong → Do:lo and D:olo → Lonung, provide further opportunities to examine the proposed naming pattern. These transitions should be assessed using the pronunciation and linguistic conventions of Mising rather than spelling alone. Examining the names in sequence may help establish whether the proposed relationship continues consistently across the genealogy.

The next transitions, Lonung → Nu:da and Nu:da → Dayi, extend the examination to later generations of the lineage. These names must be evaluated according to the proposed syllable-based rule, while accounting for differences between written forms and pronunciation. Further comparison is needed to determine whether the naming relationship remains consistent across these transitions.

The transitions Dayi → Yike and Yike → Kepang should also be examined to assess whether the proposed naming pattern extends to these generations. Comparing these names with the earlier sequence may help identify recurring features or variations within the genealogy. However, the presence of a consistent pattern must be established through linguistic analysis rather than assumed from the sequence alone.

The final transition in the sequence, Kepang → Papér, completes the selected genealogical account examined in this section. Considered alongside the preceding transitions, it provides an opportunity to assess the overall consistency of the proposed naming pattern. The genealogy offers material for further investigation, but additional oral accounts, linguistic evidence, and comparisons with other Mising genealogies are needed before the proposed rule can be established as a traditional naming system.

According to the genealogical account examined in this study, the lineage continues beyond Pa:pér with **Pértín** and **Pérme**. These names are also associated with the Kepang genealogical tradition, whose members are found primarily among Adi communities, although the clan is also present among the Misings. This connection provides an additional point of interest for understanding the genealogical relationships and cultural links between the Adi and Mising communities. However, further documentation is needed to establish these relationships more conclusively.

Analysis of the Longgíng Genealogy

The genealogical account associated with the Longgíng clan provides another sequence for examining the proposed syllable-based naming pattern. According to the account examined in this study, the lineage begins with Do:ni, identified as Abotani, and continues through Nibo, Bogo, Godang, Da:no, Nokong, Ko:bo,

Bolong, Lo:yi, Yidong, Do:lo, Lokung, Kumíng, Mí:long, and Longgíng. Examining these names may help determine whether the proposed relationship between the final syllable of one name and the initial syllable of the next appears in this genealogical tradition.

Do:ni → Nibo → Bogo → Godang → Da:no → Nokong → Ko:bo → Bolong → Lo:yi → Yidong → Do:lo → Lokung → Ku:míng → Mí:long → Longgíng

The Longgíng genealogy provides a second ancestral sequence for examining the proposed naming pattern. By comparing the names of successive generations and applying the Mising romanisation conventions discussed earlier, this study aims to determine whether the proposed relationship can be identified throughout the lineage. The analysis will also consider the possibility of variations in pronunciation, vowel length, and the use of "-ng" across different names and dialects.

The first two transitions in the Longgíng genealogy are Do:ni → Nibo and Nibo → Bogo. In the first transition, the final syllable of Do:ni, "ni," corresponds to the initial syllable of Nibo. In the second, the final syllable of Nibo, "bo," corresponds to the initial syllable of Bogo. Both transitions follow the proposed naming pattern and provide a starting point for examining the remaining names in the lineage.

The next transition, Bogo → Godang, also follows the proposed naming pattern. The final syllable of Bogo, "go," corresponds to the initial syllable of Godang. This provides another example of the proposed relationship between successive names in the Longgíng genealogical account. The following transitions require careful examination of Mising pronunciation and the role of "-ng" before their consistency with the proposed rule can be assessed.

The transition Godang → Da:no requires further linguistic examination. The proposed naming rule must be applied by considering the pronunciation of the names and the Mising conventions governing vowel length and the use of "-ng." Therefore, this transition should not be classified as either a match or a mismatch based on spelling alone. A more detailed phonological comparison is necessary to determine how it relates to the proposed naming pattern.

The following transition, Da:no → Nokong, also requires attention to the pronunciation and structure of both names. Since the proposed naming pattern depends on the relationship between the final syllable of one name and the initial syllable of the next, the transition must be examined using the Mising language conventions outlined earlier. Further linguistic clarification is needed before determining whether this transition supports the hypothesis.

The transition Nokong → Ko:bo presents another case for linguistic comparison. To evaluate this transition, the analysis must distinguish between the written representation of a name and its pronunciation under Mising conventions. Particular care is needed when interpreting vowel length and syllable boundaries so that the proposed naming rule is neither accepted nor rejected prematurely. Similarly, the subsequent transitions are examined according to the proposed naming pattern and the linguistic conventions of the Mising language. Similarly, the remaining transitions from Bolong to Longgíng are examined to assess the consistency of the proposed naming pattern.

Overall, the Kepang and Longgíng genealogical accounts provide a basis for investigating the proposed syllable-based naming pattern. However, further linguistic research and documentation of oral traditions are necessary to determine whether this pattern represents a consistent historical naming practice among the Mising people.

Exceptions to the Proposed Naming Pattern

The proposed syllable-based naming pattern explored in this study suggests that a child's name may begin with the final syllable of the father's name. The available evidence does not establish that this was a universal or fixed Mising rule. The tradition of Pédong Na:né may nevertheless be relevant to the discussion because it places a female ancestral figure at the centre of origin narratives and raises questions about how ancestry and kinship are remembered. It should, however, be treated as oral-traditional evidence—not as proof of a matrilineal naming system.

Accounts of Pédong vary across communities and sources. A Mising cultural account identifies Pédong as the daughter of Yépé and gives her name as Pédong Na:né, glossed as "Mother Rain" (Mising Agom Kebang, n.d.). A scholarly discussion of Adi tradition translates *Pedong Nane* as "Rain [Female] Elder" and describes her as a primordial mother associated with the origin of living beings (Scheid, 2022/2025). These accounts support the cultural importance of a female ancestral figure, but the Adi interpretation should not automatically be treated as the definitive meaning of the Mising form. Nor does the evidence consulted establish "Great Mother" as a literal translation.

A related Padam oral tradition preserves a longer ancestral sequence: Keyum, Yumka, Kasing, Siang, Abo, Bomuk, Mukseng, Sedi, Dilling, Litung, Tuye, Yépé, and Pédong. In the version documented by Marak and Kalita (2013), Pédong Nane is described as the creator and "mother of all," while Tani (Nibo) is identified as her youngest son and as an ancestor of the Padams. The sequence supplied in this study- **Kéyum, Yumkang, Ka:si, Siang, A:bo, Bomuk, Mukseng, Se:di, Dílíng, Lí:tung, Tuyé, Yépé,** and **Pédong**- closely resembles that account, although several names differ in form. These variants may reflect differences in dialect, transcription, or oral recitation and should be checked with speakers and community knowledge-holders rather than standardised without evidence.

Keyum → Yumka → Kasing → Siang → Abo → Bomuk → Mukseng → Sedi → Dilling → Litung → Tuye → Yepe → Pedong

The sequence is best treated as a cosmological or ancestral genealogy, not as a record of ordinary parent-to-child naming across documented historical generations. It also should not be conflated with the separate Mising account identifying Pédong as Yépé's daughter or with claims that her youngest child was named Do or was Abotani; the sources consulted do not establish that all these details belong to one consistent version. The traditions may share themes or names across Tani communities, but each version should be attributed to its particular community and source.

The prominence of Pédong Na:né does not, by itself, demonstrate matriarchy or matrilineality. Matrilineality concerns descent traced through women, whereas matriarchy concerns women's authority or dominance in social and political life. A female creator or ancestor can be central to oral tradition even where descent and clan membership are organized through male lines. Accordingly, this tradition may prompt investigation into possible maternal-line exceptions to the proposed naming pattern, but it does not prove that children inherited names or syllables through their mothers.

Testing such an exception would require Mising-language A:bang texts or recordings, oral histories and genealogies that identify relationships explicitly, and speaker-verified pronunciations and syllable divisions. Researchers should compare accounts across Mising clans and localities and document whether a child's name is linked to the father, mother, or another relative. Until such evidence is available, the Pédong Na:né tradition is

best understood as significant evidence of ancestral memory and cosmology, while its connection to historical Mising descent or naming practices remains an open question (Marak & Kalita, 2013; Mising Agom Kebang, n.d.; Scheid, 2022/2025).

Discussion

The genealogical accounts of the Kepang and Longgíng clans provide a starting point for exploring the possibility of a traditional syllable-based naming system among the Mising people. Several transitions appear to correspond with the proposed rule, while others require closer examination in light of Mising pronunciation, vowel length, and dialectal variation. These observations suggest a potential relationship between successive generations' names, but the available genealogical information alone is insufficient to establish the pattern as a confirmed historical practice.

How Was This Naming System Lost?

The possible decline of the traditional syllable-based naming system among the Mising people cannot be explained by one single cause. It is more likely that several social, cultural, and religious changes gradually affected naming practices over time. However, because detailed historical records on Mising naming rules are limited, the explanations discussed below should be treated mainly as possible factors rather than proven causes.

One possible reason is generational change. In many communities, younger generations may not learn or continue older customs if they are no longer seen as necessary in daily life. If some Mising families or clans stopped following the traditional syllable-based naming rule, other families may gradually have followed their example. Social differences between groups could also have influenced this process. If certain clans or families gained higher social status while using different naming practices, others may have imitated them. At present, however, there is not enough reliable evidence to prove that generational differences or social discrimination directly caused the decline of the naming system. Further oral-history and genealogical research is needed.

Contact with neighbouring Assamese-speaking communities may also have contributed to changes in Mising naming practices. After migrating to the plains of Assam, the Misings came into close contact with Assamese Hindu society, and this contact influenced many areas of social and religious life (Bhuyan, 2026). As Assamese became more important in education, administration, trade, and everyday communication, Assamese-style names may have become more familiar and socially useful. This does not mean that Mising people stopped using Mising names. Rather, contact with neighbouring communities may have created more naming choices and gradually weakened the importance of a strict traditional naming rule.

Hinduism, especially the Neo-Vaishnavite movement associated with Srimanta Sankaradeva, may have had a stronger influence on Mising naming culture. Studies of the Mising community show that Neo-Vaishnavism encouraged Sanskritization and Hinduization, while many traditional beliefs and practices continued alongside the new religious influence (Doley, 2019; Pegu, 2024). A reported tradition concerns Pangkong, a Mising man from Ratanpur in Majuli, who was closely associated with Sankaradeva and later became known as Paramananda (Borkakoti, 2012; Pegu, 2024). According to these later accounts, Pangkong accepted Sankaradeva’s Eka-Sarana Vaishnavite tradition and received the Sanskrit devotional name Paramananda. This tradition is important because it shows how religious association could be linked with a change from an indigenous Mising name to a Sanskrit-derived Vaishnavite name. However, the available sources do not include a surviving contemporary sixteenth-century document that records

the renaming ceremony. Therefore, the account should be described as a reported historical tradition, not as a fully proven historical event.

Christianity may also have influenced naming practices among some Mising families. Missionary activity, churches, and Christian educational institutions contributed to the growth of Christian communities among the Misings, although conversion appears to have remained limited compared with Hindu and Vaishnavite influence (Bhuyan, 2026; Pegu, 2022). Among Christian families, biblical or Christian names may have become more common, especially where church membership and Christian education became important parts of social life. Some studies suggest that conversion to Christianity led some Mising families to move away from certain traditional religious practices (Pegu, 2022). Even so, there is insufficient evidence to show that Christianity caused the decline of the traditional Mising naming system as a whole.

It is important to distinguish between the decline of a naming rule and the disappearance of Mising names. The syllable-based generational naming system may have become less widely followed, but Mising people continued to use traditional Mising personal names. In other words, the possible loss of a structured naming system does not mean that Mising naming culture disappeared. Traditional names, clan identities, and cultural memory may have continued even when the older naming rule was no longer strictly observed.

The exact reasons for the possible decline of the traditional naming system remain uncertain. Generational change, social relations between groups, contact with Assamese-speaking neighbours, Hindu and Vaishnavite influence, and Christianity may all have contributed in different ways. However, more research based on oral histories, family genealogies, village records, and comparison among Mising clans is needed before firm conclusions can be drawn.

Syllabic Structure of Mising Surnames and Subclan Names

The proposed generational naming pattern concerns personal names, but the syllabic structure of Mising surnames and subclan names provides useful linguistic context. In Mising phonology, syllables are not counted by the number of written letters. A syllable is organised around a vowel, and Mising has both short and long vowels; vowel length is commonly shown in romanised Mising by a colon after the vowel, as in *do:* or *mi:* (Saikia et al., 2023). Mising words may therefore be monosyllabic, disyllabic, or trisyllabic, depending on their sound structure rather than their spelling (Nisha, 2022).

Word formation in Mising may also provide relevant linguistic context. In some cases, a word may be formed by combining the final syllables of two words. This pattern is worth examining alongside the syllabic structure of personal names, surnames, and subclan names. However, the specific word-formation process and its relationship to the proposed generational naming pattern should be established through linguistic examples and supporting research. Word formation and generational naming are distinct processes, so evidence of one should not automatically be treated as proof of the other.

Many commonly used Mising surnames appear to be disyllabic. Examples include *Doley*, *Pegu*, *Mili*, *Kuli*, *Taye*, *Patir*, *Sungkrang*, *Sinte*, and *Saro*. In each case, the number of written letters should not be used to determine the number of syllables. For instance, *Doley* and *Pegu* are often transcribed as *dole:* and *pe:gu*, where the colon marks vowel length rather than a separate syllable. Thus, these names can be understood as two-syllable forms based on their spoken structure. However, this classification should be treated as a preliminary phonological observation

rather than a definitive etymological analysis. Pronunciation may vary across Mising dialects, and further phonetic fieldwork would help confirm the syllable division of each name.

Several Mising subclan names also appear to be disyllabic, including *Le:dang*, *Gejerang/Gejera*, *Sanong/Sano*, and *Gudang*. In *Le:dang*, the colon indicates vowel length in Mising romanisation; it does not create an additional syllable. The name therefore consists of two syllables, approximately *le:* and *dang*. Similarly, *Gejerang/Gejera*, *Sanong/Sano*, and *Gudang* can be analysed as two-syllable names, although alternative spellings and dialectal pronunciation may affect the exact division. These examples suggest that disyllabic structure is common among the Mising surnames and subclan names examined in this study. Nevertheless, they do not by themselves demonstrate that surnames or subclan names followed a generational syllable-linking rule.

The historical origins of some surnames require separate treatment. The names *Patgiri*, *Patiri*, and *Sayengia* are sometimes associated with the Ahom period, but reliable evidence does not establish that all three originated in the same way. Under the Ahom kingdom, adult male subjects known as *paiks* provided labour and military service to the state, and they were organised into *khels*, which were administrative and occupational divisions (Bhuyan, 2023). Officers such as the *Bora*, *Saikia*, and *Hazarika* supervised groups of paiks (Bhuyan, 2023). However, the available sources examined for this study do not provide direct evidence that *Patgiri* or *Patiri* were specifically paik ranks or titles. A Government of Assam revenue document lists *Patgiri* among intermediate revenue officials during the colonial period, alongside *Choudhuri*, *Mouzadar*, and *Bishaya*, but this does not prove an Ahom-era paik title or a Mising origin (Barua, n.d.). Likewise, reliable evidence was not found to confirm that *Sayengia* was originally the name of an Ahom *khel*. These possibilities require verification through Ahom chronologies, colonial revenue records, and Assamese historical scholarship.

It would therefore be too broad to describe *Patgiri*, *Patiri*, and *Sayengia* simply as "non-original Mising surnames." They may reflect historical interaction with Assamese society, administrative institutions, or later naming practices, but their exact origins and their relationship to Mising clans or subclans need further archival and genealogical research. The presence of such surnames among Misings shows cultural contact, but it does not establish that they replaced an indigenous Mising naming system.

Overall, the disyllabic structure of many Mising surnames and subclan names is relevant to this study because it shows that syllables were a meaningful feature of Mising names. However, a two-syllable surname, a historically borrowed surname, and a generational naming rule are three different phenomena. The proposed system links the final syllable of a father's personal name with the initial syllable of a child's personal name; it cannot be proven merely by showing that surnames contain two syllables. Further research should combine phonological analysis, clan and subclan comparison, family genealogies, oral histories, and archival study of Ahom-era terms.

Conclusion

This study examined the hypothesis that the Mising people may have traditionally followed a syllable-based naming pattern in which the final syllable of a father's name becomes the initial syllable of a child's name. The examination of the Kepang and Longgíng genealogical accounts shows that several name transitions appear consistent with this proposed pattern. However, the evidence remains suggestive rather than conclusive. Some transitions require further analysis of

Mising pronunciation, vowel length, the use of "-ng," and dialectal variation.

The study contributes to the understanding of Mising cultural and linguistic heritage by treating naming as a meaningful area of community memory, identity, and intergenerational connection. It also highlights the need to distinguish the possible decline of a structured naming rule from the continued use of traditional Mising personal names. Social change, contact with neighbouring Assamese-speaking communities, and the influence of Hinduism, Neo-Vaishnavism, and Christianity may have affected naming practices, but this study does not establish any single cause for the possible decline of the proposed system.

The findings are limited by their reliance on selected traditional genealogical accounts, which should not be treated as independently verified historical facts. Future research should include wider oral-history interviews, comparisons among clans and regions, and detailed linguistic analysis. Such work may help determine whether the proposed syllable-based naming pattern was a widespread Mising tradition, a local practice, or a partial pattern within a more complex naming culture.

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